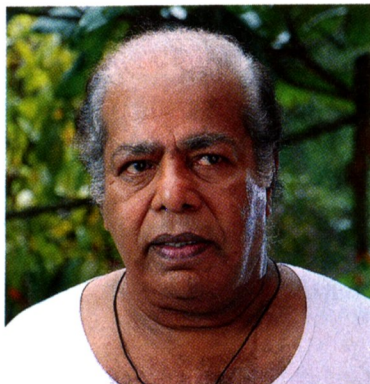


resolved to withdraw the pension it pays to senior artistes. Thilakan alleges that he was recently asked by the producer of the big budget film *Christian Brothers* not to report for shooting. "I was given the advance money and my shoot dates were fixed. Suddenly, the producer called to say he wanted me out because of pressure from some associations," he says. Thilakan was also given the boot by Sohan Roy, a US-based director from Kerala who said he was cancelling Thilakan's call sheet at the behest of film technicians.

It would have remained a war between film stars had not 85-year-old Sukumar Azhikode, Kerala's venerated culture critic, author and former chairman of National Book Trust, taken up cudgels on behalf of Thilakan. The film stars virtually walked into a trap as Azhikode—who is in the habit of intervening in most social, political and cultural issues—jumped into the fray in Thilakan's defence. He accused the actors of charging exorbitant fees which has led to the bleeding of the film industry. "These stars who make a business of their art are a shame. Who are they to attack a much senior and talented artiste like Thilakan?" he asked. He also criticised Mohanlal for appearing on jewellery ads with Hema Malini and accused Mammooty of taking Rs 5.5 crore (a very high price by Malayalam film industry standards) for his role in the recent Rs 25-crore *Pazassi Raja*, the costliest production in Malayalam cinema. He called 50-year-old Mohanlal "a hypocrite who hid his advancing age to act with younger heroines".

Mohanlal retaliated by saying that Thilakan and Azhikode were making unfounded charges. He provoked Azhikode by saying that a "writer who confesses that he never watches movies had no right to speak of cinema and actors. He should confine himself to his field and not ride on us. All us actors, including Amitabh Bachchan, appear in commercials. What business and merit he has to pontificate on cinema?" Azhikode unleashed a fierce counter-attack on



The association acts like a mafia and the artiste in me would have to contemplate suicide if they continue with their current ways.

THILAKAN

National Award-winning actor



Mohanlal and Mammooty have made a business out of art. Who are they to attack a senior and talented artiste like Thilakan?

SUKUMAR AZHIKODE

Prominent author

Mohanlal and Mammooty. "They survive on their makeup and never dare to be without it, unlike Rajnikant," he said. "Can these stars utter a single original line? How can they question the merit of a person like me who has authored 40 books and made tens of thousands of speeches in a six-decade-long career?"

Mohanlal, used only to adoration throughout his three-decade-long reign, was stunned and hit back, calling the writer deranged. He said that writing 40 books does not qualify one to comment on everything and everyone and threatened to sue Azhikode for defamation. In turn, the furious writer responded by saying he would sue the star first for calling him mad. The AMMA, led by Mammooty, came out in Mohanlal's defence and unleashed a broadside against Azhikode. Matters got so much out of hand that state Culture Minister M.A. Baby and former Justice V.R. Krishna Iyer intervened to plead for an immediate ceasefire.

Ironically, the diatribe in the Malayalam cinema has come when the industry is haemorrhaging with mounting losses and an unusual fall in quality. Year 2009 had ended in the industry losing more than Rs 150 crore as 90 per cent of the total 70 films—including Mohanlal and Mammooty starrers—had bombed at the box office. In 2008, only seven of the 67 films could recover costs. The mounting losses had made the Producers Association cut costs of films and limit a film budget to Rs 3.5 crore from the present Rs 5 crore since 50 per cent of the film's cost went into paying stars and technicians. Even at the National Awards in January 2010, Malayalam films drew a blank. Besides the financial losses, five prominent directors and artistes of the Malayalam film industry passed away in 2009.

"Malayalam cinema is lacking in quality compared to its neighbouring states," said ace Malayalam filmmaker Shaji N. Karun, chairman of 2009's National Film Award jury. Such hard times don't warrant such ugly battles, especially offscreen. ■